

Morning sickness

» What, when, and how often?

Appearing at around the fifth week of pregnancy, and usually at its worst around week 12, then disappearing by around week 20, nausea affects up to 80 percent of women. It can occur at any time of day and cause vomiting. Mild forms cause pervading feelings of nausea. Hyperemesis gravidarum is a stronger form of the condition, but is not common.

» What causes them?

Sudden increased production of pregnancy hormones that upset the gut, as well as a slowing down of the passage of food and waste material through it.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Morning sickness is generally a good sign that your body

is working hard to maintain your pregnancy. Hyperemesis gravidarum may, on rare occasions, lead to a baby having low birth weight due to it not getting enough nutrients from you, but overall, women who suffer with morning sickness are statistically less likely to have miscarriages or babies that are born prematurely.

» What can I do?

Snack little and often (see p.58), even if dry crackers are all you can keep down. Try not to have snacks that are high in refined sugar. Avoid strong-smelling and strong-tasting foods, and foods with a high fat content. Drink plenty of fluids and get plenty of rest. See your doctor if you're vomiting three or more times a day, or if you can't face eating anything at all.



Hyperemesis gravidarum

Hyperemesis gravidarum occurs in less than 2 percent of pregnant women. It's a severe form of morning sickness, characterized by frequent vomiting. If you are experiencing this condition and are unable to keep any food or drink down for more than 24 hours then you need to visit your doctor. You will most likely have your urine tested to make sure you don't have an infection. You might also be given an ultrasound to rule out any issues with your pregnancy. You will be weighed and if you have lost more than 10 percent of your body weight then you are likely to experience complications with your pregnancy. Your doctor might send you to the hospital if you are very dehydrated and you will stay there until you are well enough to go home. In the hospital you will be given intravenous fluids, antinausea medicine, and possibly a vitamin supplement. The good news is that hyperemesis usually disappears when you are 13 weeks pregnant.

Nap time Try to take short naps or have periods of rest to help deal with the draining feeling that nausea and vomiting bring.

Heartburn and indigestion

» What, when, and how often?

Indigestion is the feeling that you have something permanently stuck in your windpipe, and may make you feel sick or as if you want to burp. Heartburn causes a burning sensation in your throat—it's usually a side effect of indigestion and often occurs after you've eaten. It is known medically as acid reflux. Around 80 percent of pregnant women suffer from indigestion during pregnancy, and it's more likely to occur if this is a second or subsequent pregnancy.

» What causes them?

Everything in your abdomen is squashed as your baby grows, which means that your intestines get pushed upward, making it harder for food to flow seamlessly

through your system. This, along with the slowed-down action of your intestine (caused by increased progesterone), means that your stomach acid remains in contact with the lining of your stomach longer than it should, irritating it and causing the symptoms of indigestion. The relaxing of your muscles during pregnancy also relaxes a valve at the bottom of your esophagus, that normally prevents stomach acid from escaping back up to your throat.

» What does it mean for my pregnancy?

There is nothing sinister about indigestion during pregnancy and it poses no risks to you or your baby.

» What can I do?

Avoid spicy or highly flavored foods, and eat little and often so that your stomach has as little to deal with at a time as possible. If your indigestion is affecting your life (perhaps you constantly feel sick or you're burping), you may be able to take antacids to help settle things, but you will need to consult your doctor first.

Try propping yourself up with cushions at night or if you're having a nap during the day. This helps to prevent the acids in your stomach from coming up into your throat.

Flatulence

» What, when, and how often?

Unfortunately, pregnancy can increase the likelihood that you'll need to expel gas from your anus—flatulence. It affects almost all pregnant women at some time during their pregnancy.

» What causes it?

Certain foods, such as those high in fat or carbohydrate, are harder for your body to break down. During pregnancy they spend longer in your intestine than they would if you weren't pregnant and they create gas as they sit there. You expel this gas as flatulence.